

Substantive Change Application Form

Competency-Based Education

Directions: This application should be submitted at *least* 30 days prior to the anticipated start date of the change. Applications must be complete and the required fees received to be scheduled for review.

Email completed application to substantivechange@accjc.org. Fees must be submitted to the Accrediting Commission for Community and Junior Colleges
P.O. Box 147, Novato, CA 94948

Date of Inquiry: 3/15/2023
Anticipated Start Date: 08/01/2024

Institution Name: Merced Community College District
Address: 3600 M Street
City: Merced
State: CA
Zip: 95348

ALO Name:
Telephone:
Email:

Title of Application and Description of Proposal:

Merced Community College district (Merced College) is seeking accreditation for a Direct Assessment, Competency Based Education (DA, CBE) program including an AA in Child Development, AS-T in Early Childhood Education, CT in Administration in Early Childhood Education, CT in Early Intervention Assistant Specialization, CT in Families in Crisis Specialization, CT in Infant/Toddler Care, and CT in School-Age Care Specialization. The substantive change proposal details the development and implementation of the Child Development program, which expands access and educational opportunities for the current and future early education workforce. The competency-based education (CBE) model provides a skills-based curriculum that can be achieved according to a flexible pace for students contending with potentially disruptive life events or obligations. Merced College is one of eight campuses in the California Community Colleges System currently collaborating to build a model for direct assessment CBE or other California Community Colleges.

This proposal describes Merced College's planning process for designing and sustaining the CBE program in Child Development and how it aligns with the College's mission and goals of the campus, the impact and benefits of the CBE Child Development Program, how the campus will assess and validate the CBE Program in Child Development Associate of Arts Program, and the labor market demands of Merced County.

Standard I: Mission, Academic Quality, and Institutional Effectiveness and Integrity

Briefly describe the planning process that identified and led to the competency-based education program(s).
The California Community College's State Chancellor's Office released a Request for Proposal for the CBE Direct Assessment Collaborative Grant. Merced College was one of eight colleges selected to participate in the CBE initiative and one of only three selected to generate data for a case study. The Merced College planning process involved presenting the CBE initiative to the following participatory governance committees: Academic Senate, Student Senate, Instructional Council, Student Services Council, and College Council. Faculty from various instructional divisions, student services, both Student and Academic Senate presidents in addition to Institutional research formed workgroups after the Merced College community agreed to participate in the CBE initiative (CBE-E-01). Collectively, the Merced College community selected 8 classes within the Child Development Associates Degree to serve as the inaugural CBE program course alignment model. These 8 foundational courses are aligned with the Child Development Training Consortium CAP 8, a 24-unit lower division program of study which supports early care and education (ECE) teacher preparation.
Describe how the competency-based education program(s) is consistent with the mission and goals of the institution.
Merced College provides innovative and high-quality educational programs and services to our regional communities. We support life-long learning and student success by utilizing proven educational methodologies as determined by collaborative institutional planning and assessment. To meet the surrounding economic and workforce development needs, Merced College offers basic skills, transfer-level general and career education, associate degrees, and certificates. Our commitment to learning empowers and educates students for effective and positive change to enhance our world. The Child Development-Competency Based Education (CLDV-CBE) program offers an educational modality which delivers responsive training for the educational needs of students and employers within Merced College's service area and surrounding region.
The CLDV-CBE supports Merced College's vision by offering a high-quality program based on "Ensuring student success through equitable access, continuous quality improvement, institutional

effectiveness, and student achievement” (CBE-E-02). Goal 1 of the Merced College Educational Master Plan (EMP) supports the CLDV-CBE by “employ[ing] enrollment management strategies to support student success, progression, and completion/transfer.” (CBE-E-03). The stated objectives of the EMP Goal 1 relevant to the CLDV-CBE are:

- 1.3 Program Development: “design and develop innovative programs and expand educational programming to meet workforce needs,”
- 1.4 Workforce Needs: “provide just-in-time and advanced technical training to meet workforce needs,”
- 1.5 Expansion of Educational Offerings: “expand coursework and certificate and degree programs to align with area workforce needs,”
- 1.6 Program Viability: “create innovative packaging and delivery of programs and expand distance education offerings.”

The CLDV-CBE program creatively meets the needs of working and parenting adults who urgently need upskilling and credentialing in Early Childhood Education due to new state regulations. Moreover, its method of instruction maximizes flexibility through innovations in instruction, assessment, scheduling, and student services, especially with regard to financial aid. EMP Goal 5 states that Merced College will “strengthen existing and create new partnerships with educational institutions, employers, and government and community agencies to support EMP goals” (CBE-E-03). The corresponding stated objectives of EMP Goal 5 relevant to the CLDV-CBE are:

- 5.3 Increase reach: “Strengthen K-12 partnerships”
- 5.4 Support workforce needs: “Partner with Employers, foundations, community groups and government agencies (city, county, state)”

Following the alignment with our institutional vision and mission, the CLDV-CBE program at Merced College will build on its successful programming for adult learners. It will also support the desired outcomes of the Merced College EMP with:

- 1) Increased student access and success
- 2) Current, relevant, well-designed educational programs responsive to student and community needs, provided in user-friendly pathways and delivery modes
- 3) Efficient and effective systems and processes leading to integrated planning and institutional effectiveness
- 4) Robust external partnerships that enhance resources and support the above outcomes.

What is the expected impact of the competency-based education program(s)? What benefits will result from the competency-based education program(s)?

Delivering coursework via the CBE modality will increase the potential for non-traditional students to matriculate through degree programs at their own pace by the demonstration of skills mastered across life experiences. Moreover, CBE is an equity-minded approach to earning college units which aligns with Merced College’s EMP Goals 1 and 5 (CBE-E-03). At this time, the Child Development Core 8 classes have been mapped into CBE competencies and milestones (see below) which represent 24 units of coursework within the Child Development degrees and certificates. In the near future additional General Education (GE) courses will be mapped to competencies.

As a modality, CBE pathways will have the following impacts for Merced College students:

- Decreased time to graduation as competencies are demonstrated
- Flexibility in course pacing
- Flexibility in transitioning among modalities to ensure that students are retained within

degree programs

- Increasing student autonomy over their learning
- Individualized learning which accommodates for various learning styles

How will the institution assess and validate the quality/efficacy of the competency-based education program(s)? How will the program(s) be incorporated into the college's integrated planning processes?

Merced College CBE pathways will be assessed using institutional tools already implemented to determine the efficacy of face-to-face and distance education modalities within courses and programs. These processes include Student Learning Outcomes (SLO)/Program Learning Outcomes (PLO) assessment, Instructional Program Review, Advisory Board reviews and C-BEN alignment.

The assessment SLOs is completed in alternate years in order to determine if there are gaps in student learning within a course. Each course SLO is mapped to one or more PLOs thereby allowing the assessment of program outcomes using course SLO data. These data, in addition to Institutional Effectiveness metrics, are used to evaluate programs in their entirety through the Instructional Program Review (IPR) process. It is important to note that IPR data discriminate among course offering methodologies to ensure that student learning goals are being met across all modalities. The IPR is an integral component of accreditation, assessment, planning and budgeting at Merced College. The evaluation and recommendations from each IPR provide the basis for informed decision-making on programs, curriculum, personnel, facilities, and resource allocation (CBE-E-04). Annual program reviews and planning align with Merced College's planning calendar.

In addition to utilizing learning outcomes assessment and the IPR process, Career Technical Education (CTE) programs offering degrees through a CBE modality may utilize Advisory Board reviews and annual committee meetings to assess the effectiveness of their CBE pathway. This will promote input from community partners, current/prior students, other neighboring institutions of higher learning, and community stakeholders in order to ensure that the content meets the needs of our community. Many Boards communicate through formal meetings and ongoing informal interactions.

Merced College CBE pathways will also align with the Competency-Based Education Network's (C-BEN) Quality Framework for Competency-Based Education (CBE-E-05). This alignment includes standards for continuous improvement of the competency-based program itself, as well as each degree or certificate offered in the competency-based modality. Key performance indicators in the CBE program, or "milestones," include;

- competency completion
- time for competency attainment,
- student retention,
- number of attempts to reach mastery of each competency,
- time to complete credential,
- student cost for the program, and
- postgraduate completion of outcomes, such as job placement and living wage.

Moving forward, all Merced College CBE program pathways will follow the same process for review and validation, including both student and alumni engagement and advisory board engagement before program development and selection.

Standard II: Instructional Programs

What type of approach will be used for the competency-based education program(s)?
The Merced College Child Development CBE Program will be delivered both online and in person. ☒ All online ☒ In-person ☒ Direct assessment approach ☐ Hybrid approach
Describe the college's definition of credit or clock hour.
The clock hour calculation process is in conjunction with the California Community College Board Policy (BP) and Administrative Procedures (AP); BP 4020 Program, Curriculum, and Course Development (CBE-E-06) and AP 4020 Program, Curriculum, and Course Development (CBE-E-07), and Student Attendance Accounting Manual (CBE-E-08.) According to MCCD Administrative Procedure 4620 (CBE-E-09), "One credit hour of community college work (one unit of credit) shall require a minimum of 54 semester hours of total student work, which may include inside and/or outside-of 3 class hours. A course requiring 108 hours or more total student work shall provide at least 2 units of credit." The district calculates units based on the following formula: Total Contact (In-Class) Hours + Outside-of-Class Hours = Units District Divisor (54)
Describe methodology that will be used to equate direct assessment to credit or clock hours.
Direct Assessment CBE is a flexible, learner-paced and equity-minded modality of learning which results in the acquisition of a degree or credential from an institution of learning. Competency Based Education programs will foster more equitable outcomes through flexible methods and timelines and credit for existing knowledge. The college's methodology to equate direct assessment to credit and clock hours occurs in two phases: (a) The college conducts a mapping and outline process. Faculty develop a content outline that specifies the learning activities, assessments, practicum, etc. that will make up the course content. (b) The faculty use a time-based learning calculation to determine the amount of time to which each module equates. During or within the mapping and outline process, faculty identify the academic content, assessments (formative and summative), activities, and exercises required to develop and demonstrate proficiency in each competency. These elements are then compared to existing credit-based courses with one of the three following mapping objectives and outcomes: • Simple (S), • Together (T), or • Multiple (M) courses. ● S represents a direct, one-to-one match, where a competency maps neatly to one existing course's objectives and student learning outcomes. ● T means that multiple competencies collaborate to map to a course's objectives and student

learning outcomes.

- In *M*, a single, more comprehensive competency maps to the outcomes for multiple courses' outcomes and student learning outcomes.

These steps are delineated in the mapping and content outline process document. This flexible, learner-centered mapping strategy prioritizes the academic content, activities, and assessments learners need to master competency of pre-existing course outlines of record, not the mere adherence of them.

The credit awarded is the total amount given for all the mapped courses, as with a credit-hour modality based on the learning activities. The process includes a comparison of the proposed competency to an existing course in the credit-hour program for the gap analysis. The process is completed for all competencies in the program. Any new course content needed to support the program should be developed, reviewed, and approved following the college's existing curriculum process, as this is the purview of faculty.

Next, faculty take the developed outline and perform the time-based learning calculation, as described in the time-based learning calculation document (Time-Based Learning Calculation) to determine the amount of time for each module. The college plans to conduct a time-based learning calculation for each competency to align with the credit hour, as defined in the Board Policy (BP) and Administrative Policy (AP) documents; BP 4020 Program, Curriculum, and Course Development; AP 4020 Program, Curriculum, and Course Development. The overall degree must align with the time-based calculation and total units (60) of the Associate of Arts degree.

What are the program(s) competencies and how does the institution determine they are the appropriate level and complexity congruent with the achievement expected at the relevant degree level for an institution of higher learning?

Merced College Child Development Local Associate's of Arts Degree is establishing industry-validated competencies that adopt the language of the early education workforce and employers. To help learners be workforce ready, the college will "translate" employer language and map it back to its academic language, instead of prioritizing academic language and then expecting industry stakeholders to interpret its meaning.

The California Community College Early Childhood Educator faculty aligned all child development coursework via the Curriculum Alignment Program (CAP) project. This large initiative streamlined statewide child development courses with the standards set by associate's degree for transfer and met the Commission on Teacher Credentialing (CTC) Child Development Teacher Permit course requirements. These efforts have enabled early education students to enroll in child development courses at any community college in California and earn a degree that leads to employment. This effort was fully supported by the California Community College Chancellor's Office, whose 114 state community colleges aligned curriculum to support California students graduating from their academic pursuits to the workforce.

In the development of these CBE competencies, Merced Child Development Faculty, in collaboration with Shasta College faculty, developed **8 core competencies** that align with CAP and with the California Child Development Permit from the Commission on Teacher Credentialing.

The following is the proposed institutional, degree relevant, competencies:

Merced College
Child Development/Early Care & Education

COMPETENCY SET OUTLINE:

- 3 Levels (Level 0, Level 1, Level 2)
- 5 Modules (Module 0-4)
- **8 Competencies** (C 1-8)
- 24 Milestones (M 1-24)
- 24 Equivalent Units

8 SPECIFIC COMPETENCIES FOR COMPLETION:

1. *Principles & Practices*
2. *Health, Safety & Nutrition*
3. *Child Development*
4. *Child, Family & Community*
5. *Introduction to Curriculum*
6. *Observation and Assessment*
7. *Teaching in a Diverse Society*
8. *Practicum*

Curricular modules provide the knowledge, skills, abilities, and behaviors needed for *mastery* of each competency. Students will complete summative and formative assessments that require demonstration of mastery of each competency to earn credit and advance in the program. The program competencies document clearly identifies and describes each performance-based outcome.

Through the competency outline and credit hour crosswalk process, Merced College's Child Development faculty will map the direct assessment CBE degree back to our current Child Development associate's degree which will also be offered in a traditional format.

How the Competency Set Aligns with California's EARLY CHILDHOOD/CD Resources

- **Milestones** (CAP 8 SLOs x3 per Milestone)
- **Competencies** (CAP 8 Courses cross-walked to TPE and NAEYC)
- **3 Levels** (for CA employability similar to New York's Early Childhood Career Ladder. Additional levels, 3 for Master Teacher and 4 for Site Supervisor, can be added later)
- **Formative and Summative Assessment** (CA ECE TPA, CA ECE OER, CAP Methods of Evaluation, SME Created, etc.)
- **Levels of Mastery** (80% "Developing" from ECE CompStat 2018 Rubric Level "Planning and Guiding Early Learning and Development")

Curricular modules are being created to provide learners the knowledge, skills, abilities, and behaviors needed to demonstrate mastery of each competency. Students will complete summative assessments that require demonstration of mastery of each competency to earn credit and move forward in the program. The program competencies document states clearly what the performance-based outcomes look like for each competency.

Through the competency outline and credit hour crosswalk process, utilized through Merced College's Child Development faculty will map the direct assessment CBE degree back to our current AS-T in

Child Development, which is also offered in a traditional format. Additionally, other programs, degrees, and certificates will also use this methodology in the future.

Describe how regular and substantive interaction between faculty and student will occur in the competency-based education program(s).

In compliance with ACCJC's Policy on Distance Education and Correspondence Education, ACCJC Accreditation Standard II, Title IV federal regulations, and California's Title 5 regulations, regular and substantive interaction will occur in two or more of the following ways:

(i) Providing direct instruction – This will be accomplished through options that include pre-recorded course materials, small group discussions with learners at the same place in the curriculum, or through one-on-one coaching calls.

(ii) Assessing or providing feedback on a student's coursework – Faculty members will create formative and summative assessments. These assessments may be scored automatically, with faculty members providing substantive feedback responses built into the assessment for correct and incorrect answers. Alternatively, faculty may also respond with individualized feedback. Performance-based summative assessments will require individualized feedback from faculty, primarily through feedback on a standardized rubric with additional feedback as necessary on each competency. Faculty members may meet with learners one-on-one to discuss performance deficiencies and strengths related to competency development.

(iii) Providing information or responding to questions about the content of a course or competency - Where possible, the CLDV will use monitoring tools and automatically send customized messages from faculty members to learners who are not meeting pre-planned targets. If the learner responds to the email, it will go directly to the faculty member for an individualized response.

(iv) Facilitating a group discussion regarding the content of a course or competency - Throughout the competency-based design, the college will intentionally build in opportunities for learner-to-learner collaboration and learner-to-faculty learning. This method may include discussion boards, small group meetings, or topic-based mini-lectures.

(v) Other instructional activities approved by the institution or program accrediting agency - In some courses, faculty members may conduct performance-based demonstrations of competence with the learners. Based on the competency and the expected performance, other activities may be needed. Faculty-initiated activity will be embedded in each competency.

Standard III: Resources

Human Resources

How does the institution ensure faculty responsible for the competency-based education program(s) has the appropriate academic qualifications?

Recruiting and selecting administrators, faculty, and staff occurs in strict compliance with California and federal legislation. Merced College Board Policies and Administrative Procedures ensure selection of dedicated employees to provide educational experiences, intellectual insights, and exemplary

support services necessary to optimize student potential and facilitate achievement of individual goals for the success of the educational community. See BP 7120 Employee Recruitment and Selection (CBE-E-10).

Merced College also adheres to BP 7210, Academic Employees (CBE-E-11), BP 7214, Faculty Hiring (CBE-E-12) and AP 7120, Recruitment and Selection (CBE-E-13), AP 7211, Faculty Service Areas, Minimum Qualifications, and Equivalencies (CBE-E-14), and AP 7214, Faculty Hiring (CBE-E-15), that dictate the role of the search committee in determining if minimum qualifications are met in faculty hiring and explains the process for determining equivalency: Qualifications that are “same as” or “equal to” those established in the disciplines list approved by the Board of Governors of the California Community Colleges and published in the CCCCCO handbook and Minimum Qualifications for Faculty and Administrators in California Community Colleges (CBE-E-16.) For courses that have multiple competencies, faculty must meet these requirements for each competency and/or each course to which they are assigned.

Specifically, the minimum qualification is a master’s degree in the discipline of the assignment, or a bachelor’s degree in the discipline of the assignment and a master’s degree in a reasonably related discipline.

The minimum qualification to teach in the child development and/or early childhood education discipline is a master’s in child development; a master’s in early childhood education, human development, home economics, or family and consumers studies, with a specialization in child development; or a master’s in early childhood education or educational psychology, with a specialization in child development/early childhood education.

OR

A bachelor’s degree in any of the above and a master’s in social work, educational supervision, elementary education, special education, psychology, bilingual bicultural, family life studies, or family and consumer studies.

Or the equivalent.

Merced College has hiring authority and must adhere to the minimum qualifications when establishing hiring criteria and/or determining hiring eligibility. The college may include criteria over and above the minimum, but can never hire below the minimum qualifications.

Furthermore, faculty will receive training and guidance specific to competency-based curriculum and assessment development and training on CBEN’s Quality Framework for CBE updated manual. This is required reading for faculty seeking to teach in the CBE modality. The faculty will also be required to participate in the C-Ben’s competent, an online, self-paced training for CBE faculty.

Financial Resources

Describe potential impacts, if any, on institutional resources as a result of the competency-based education program(s).

In 2021, Merced College was among eight community colleges accepted into the California State Chancellor’s Office Direct Assessment Competency-Based Education Collaborative. Each will receive

\$515,000 over the next 4 years to help implement a Direct Assessment competency-based education program. The collaborative is also supported with specialized training, professional development, and targeted subject matter experts (SME). Additionally, Merced College has leveraged over \$287,000 in other grant funding from Guided Pathways, Perkins, Strong Workforce, and Career Education. Future funding is expected from the California Community College's Chancellor's Office. The College views CBE as an opportunity to engage additional students by creating additional avenues toward degree completion.

Standard IV: Leadership and Governance

What leadership and governance oversight exists at the college to ensure the continued academic quality and institutional effectiveness are maintained and sustained with competency-based education programs?

Merced College boasts strong and highly committed leaders among the ranks of its faculty, classified professionals, managers, and students. Led by the College President, they support a culture of innovation, continual improvement, and excellence. College-wide engagement and discussions about innovation and excellence are further supported through a variety of channels that exemplify inclusivity, collaboration, and respect. Merced College supports an annual innovation fund and the President generates ongoing opportunities for dialogue that further support excellence and innovation.

CBE is integrated as a standing report item through the College's various planning and participatory governance committees. Additionally, CBE is shared throughout the college via newsletters, events (e.g., FLEX), and planning committees (CBE-E-17.)

Additionally, the Merced College Board of Trustees supported the application of CBE at their March 9th, 2021 meeting (CBE-E-18.) The college is committed to leveraging multiple grants (CCCCO CBE Grant, Guided Pathways, Strong Workforce, Perkins) and general funds to support this endeavor. To provide programmatic support for CBE, the activities are braided into unitary-level planning through the program and department review process and are surfaced through wing-level and college-level planning meetings. Annual reviews and unit and college-level outreach continue to promote awareness and support for CBE.

To bolster CBE, Merced College developed a CBE Leadership Team to advise on the grant application, review implementation plans, and advise on activities. This cross-functional team also critiques proposals from the CBE Core Team; attends collaborative meetings and webinars; and advises on CBE-related technology, student experiences, systems issues related to implementation, and broader decisions about the CBE program. Their work is supported by four core members who collaborate with the President and Vice Presidents of Instruction and Student Services. C-BEN offers further consulting to meet the Quality Framework for CBE programs. Finally, the work is led by multiple dean's, directors, staff, and faculty who are accountable for the implementation effort. To engage with internal and external stakeholders, the college has conducted multiple presentations.

Evidence

Please include any relevant documentation (evidence) that will help the Committee understand the proposed CBE program(s).	
CBE Program Evidence	
Description	Name/Link
Academic Senate Meeting Minutes: 02-25-21	CBE-E-01
Merced College Vision Statement	CBE-E-02
2018-2023 Educational Master Plan	CBE-E-03
Instructional Program Review	CBE-E-04
C-BEN Quality Framework	CBE-E-05
BP 4020 CCCB Program, Curriculum, and Course Development	CBE-E-06
AP 4020 CCCB Program, Curriculum, and Course Development	CBE-E-07
Student Attendance Accounting Manual 2022	CBE-E-08
AP 4620 Merced College Credit Hour Definition	CBE-E-09
BP 7120 Employee Recruitment and Selection	CBE-E-10
BP 7210 Academic Employees	CBE-E-11
BP 7214 Faculty Hiring	CBE-E-12
AP 7120 Recruitment and Selection	CBE-E-13
AP 7211 Faculty Service Areas, Minimum Qualifications, and Equivalencies	CBE-E-14
AP 7214 Faculty Hiring	CBE-E-15
CCCCO Minimum Qualifications Handbook	CBE-E-16
Academic Senate Meeting Minutes: 09-09-21	CBE-E-17
Board of Trustees Approval	CBE-E-18
Additional Resources:	
Curriculum Alignment Project	CBE-E-19
A Leaders Guide to Competency-Based Education, Bushway et al., 2018	CBE-E-20